Tata Sons, in March 1991 placed him in a position to steer the House of Tatas through a new economic landscape, taking his vision forward.

In 1991, the new government at the Centre spearheaded several changes, liberalizing the nation's economy. As an adjunct to the liberalization policy, it also prised open the nation's doors to global competition. The hitherto-shielded Indian industrial houses now scurried for protection from foreign companies. Many of them fought hard to keep away overseas competition. In this scenario, the question of Indian companies staging a counter-invasion was unthinkable; they neither had the confidence nor the vision. But Ratan thought differently.

As he said in an interview for Harvard Business School many years later, 'One thing that struck me at that time was the fact that you were dependent on one economy, the Indian economy … That led to a view—should we not look with greater vigour beyond the shores of India so that we had the hedging of two or three economies that might offset the effects of one?'

By going overseas, Ratan assessed that national companies, besides benefiting from new technology, would attain the presence and scale necessary to tide through difficult times in India.

During the transition of the millennium, Ratan more emphatically asserted his view that the group needed to venture outside India. He pushed the idea with a sense of urgency. At the JRD QV Award function in 2002, he said, 'If we have to survive, we have to go beyond the shores of India … Our horizons have to be on a more global or regional basis.'

In a conversation with *The Wall Street Journal*, he laid out another of his reasons for adopting this approach. He said: 'Acquisitions can yield quicker presence, and can build on target-firm assets such as customer connections and managerial talent.' Another equally compelling motivation was his conviction that acquiring established and famous brands would obviate the need for the group to commit huge investments and wait out decades for global reputation to be built. In contrast, through acquisitions, it could achieve brand value and gain access to new technology and innovative products without having to depend on the time-consuming organic-growth route.

There were clear indications even before the end of the twentieth century that the time for the first of the Tata Group's global acquisitions would be nigh. Ratan had assumed the role of the 'architect of the group's global expansion policy'. He became a vanguard for others to do so too. As *The*